PLAYTEST REFERENCE MANUAL

AC

Arcane Compositry

Player's Field Codex

A fast-reference guide to improvised magic, Tendril circuitry, Catalysts, Applied Thaumaturgy, Counter-Compositry, and the combat systems that make magic an active exchange.

> **Core idea:** Choose what the magic is made of, choose what it does, choose how it manifests, choose how hard you push it - then pay the Mana.

DESIGNED FOR TABLE USE - RULES FIRST, LORE SECOND, QUICK REFERENCE LAST

NAVIGATION

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AT THE TABLE

Players: pages 3-12 cover Arcane construction; pages 19-28 explain Attack Chains, active defense, and Momentum Dice. Pages 29-30 are table references.

Quick Start: Build a Spell in 6 Steps

> Component(s) + Form + Potency + Modifiers = Composition

1 Choose Components

What is the magic made of? A spell may use a **Physical**, an **Aspectual**, or both.

2 Choose Form

How does it appear? Projectile, burst, wall, field, infusion, armor, bind, beam, and so on.

3 Choose Potency

Potency I-IX sets the spell's base Mana and damage scale.

4 Add Modifiers

Extra Components, range, area, duration, and conditions raise Mana cost.

5 Resolve It

Direct attacks roll d20 + PB + Invocation Modifier. Saving throws use DC 8 + PB + Invocation Modifier.

6 Describe It

The rules decide power. The player decides how the Composition looks, moves, sounds, and interacts with the scene.

Two-Minute Explanation for New Players

"Tell me what material or magical property you want, what shape the spell takes, and how much power you want to put into it. We use Potency to get the base numbers, then add Mana for anything extra. If it attacks, roll your normal Arcane attack. If it forces a save, I tell the target what save makes sense."

Fast Example

Geo · Fire · Projectile · Potency III

Concept: "I condense a fist-sized chunk of molten stone and fire it at the enemy."

Result: Potency III gives the starting Mana and damage pool. Geo + Fire adds a Composite cost. The projectile is single-target, so it normally uses d8 damage dice.

FOUNDATIONS

Spell Grammar: What Am I Actually Building?

01

Physical

Question: What exists?

Physical Components create or manipulate tangible substances.

Geo · Water · Iron · Flora · Fiber · Sand · Celestial

Aspectual

Question: What property is applied?

Aspectual Components add a magical state, force, or behavior.

Fire · Ice · Lightning · Poison · Volatility

Form

Question: How does it manifest?

Form controls delivery rather than magical substance.

Projectile · Burst · Wall · Field · Infusion · Armor

Components Can Stand Alone

BUILD	WHAT IT MIGHT MEAN
Geo + Projectile	Conjure or tear loose a stone and launch it.
Fire + Burst	A pure magical flare or explosion; no Physical Component required.
Water + Field	Flood or saturate an area.
Iron + Armor	Reinforce existing armor or sheath the body in conjured metal.

Composites Combine Behaviors

COMPOSITE	NATURAL INTERPRETATION	POSSIBLE FREE MINOR CONSEQUENCE
Geo + Fire	Molten stone, burning rock, volcanic plating	Leaves hot terrain or ignites fragile material
Water + Ice	Flash-freezing water, ice growth	Slippery or frozen surface
Water + Lightning	Conductive current through liquid	Electricity follows wet pathways
Sand + Fire	Heated sand, glass formation at sufficient power	Sharp or brittle terrain

Rule of thumb: small effects that logically emerge from the material may be free. Strong mechanical conditions still cost Mana.

Potency & the Mana Formula

02

Potency is how hard the user pushes reality. It is the anchor for both Mana and damage.

POTENCY	CORE MANA	TABLE MEANING
I	2	Minor combat magic
II	3	Reliable adventuring magic
III	5	Major encounter magic
IV	6	High-impact magic
V	7	Severe battlefield power
VI	9	Exceptional magic
VII	10	Elite / legendary scale
VIII	11	World-shaping potential
IX	13	Extreme reality alteration

Master Mana Formula

```
Final Mana = Core Mana + Composite + Range + Area + Duration + Effect
```

WHERE DO THE INPUTS COME FROM?

Core Mana: look up the chosen Potency in the table.

Composite: count how many Components are synchronized.

Range: choose the farthest distance the spell can reach.

Area: estimate the space affected.

Duration: how long the effect remains active.

Effect: any extra mechanical condition beyond straightforward damage or utility.

Worked Example - Molten Stone Burst

Goal: Geo + Fire, Potency III, 60-foot range, 20-foot burst, instantaneous, no added condition.

Math: 5 Core + 1 Composite + 1 Range + 2 Area + 0 Duration + 0 Effect = **9 Mana**.

Mana Modifiers: What Makes a Spell Expensive?

Composite Cost

COMPONENTS	COST
1 Component	+0
2 Components	+1
3 Components	+3
4 Components	+5 or more

Range Cost

MAXIMUM RANGE	COST
Self / Touch / 30 ft	+0
60 ft	+1
120 ft	+2
300 ft	+3

Area Cost

APPROX. AREA	COST
Single / tiny	+0
10 ft	+1
20 ft	+2
40 ft	+3
60 ft	+4

Duration Cost

DURATION	COST
Instant / one Attack Chain	+0
Up to 1 minute, Concentration	+1
Up to 10 minutes, Concentration	+2
Up to 1 hour	+3
Remove Concentration	Usually +2 more

Effect Cost

RANK	EXAMPLES	COST
Cosmetic	Light, color, sparks	+0
Minor	Push 5 ft, -10 speed, difficult terrain	+1
Strong	Prone, disarm, ongoing damage	+2
Major	Restrain, significant blindness, denial	+3
Extreme	Stun / paralysis-like control	+4; usually Potency V+

> **Design rule:** the system rarely says "you cannot." It usually says "yes, but reality charges more Mana."

Damage Formula: How Hard Does It Hit?

04

```
Damage Dice = P + 2 + floor(P / 3)
```

P means Potency. **floor** means divide, then always round down.

P	CALCULATION	DICE
I	1 + 2 + floor(1/3)	3
II	2 + 2 + floor(2/3)	4
III	3 + 2 + floor(3/3)	6
IV	4 + 2 + floor(4/3)	7
V	5 + 2 + floor(5/3)	8
VI	6 + 2 + floor(6/3)	10
VII	7 + 2 + floor(7/3)	11
VIII	8 + 2 + floor(8/3)	12
IX	9 + 2 + floor(9/3)	14

Then choose the die by Form

DELIVERY	DIE	REASON
Precise single-target	d8	Standard focused damage
Heavy / risky / exposed	d10	Reward for a real drawback
Area effect	d6	Can affect several targets
Persistent damage	d4	May trigger repeatedly

EXAMPLE

Potency III gives **6 dice**. A single-target Ice Spear becomes **6d8**. A 20-foot Ice Burst becomes **6d6**.

Conditions Trade Away Damage

```
Final Damage Dice = Normal Dice - Effect Rank
```

A Potency III spell normally has 6 dice. If it also carries a Rank II control effect, it deals **4 dice + the condition**. This keeps control magic from also being the best raw damage.

Environmental discount: if an abundant Physical Component already exists nearby, reduce the spell's Mana by 1 (minimum total cost 1). The battlefield becomes part of the spellbook.

Attack Rolls, Save DCs & Every Formula Input

05

Direct Spell Attack

```
d20 + PB + IM
```

PB - Proficiency Bonus: the normal proficiency bonus on the character sheet, determined by character level.

IM - Invocation Modifier: the ability modifier used to control this particular magical technique.

USER / TECHNIQUE	TYPICAL IM
Wizard	Intelligence
Cleric	Wisdom
Sorcerer	Charisma
Applied Thaumaturgy: force / impact	Strength
Applied Thaumaturgy: speed / precision	Dexterity
Applied Thaumaturgy: body / armor	Constitution

Arcane Save DC

```
8 + PB + IM
```

Use this when the Composition forces the target to resist rather than when the caster aims an attack roll.

EXAMPLE

Level 5 character: PB +3. Invocation ability modifier +4.

Save DC = 8 + 3 + 4 = 15.

Which Saving Throw?

WHAT THE TARGET MUST DO	SAVE
Leap away / avoid an explosion	DEX
Resist shove, crushing, restraint	STR
Endure poison, freezing, body effect	CON
Resist perception / mental manipulation	WIS / INT
Resist soul / identity manipulation	CHA

Important: the element does not choose the save. The danger does. A Geo projectile might be DEX; a closing stone prison might be STR.

Existing D&D Spells & Maximum Mana

06

Codified Spell Mana

Existing D&D spells are already-optimized magical formulas. Keep their normal statistics and replace spell slots with Mana.

SPELL LEVEL	MANA
Cantrip	0
1	2
2	3
3	5
4	6
5	7
6	9
7	10
8	11
9	13

Example: Fireball = 3rd-level = 5 Mana. Misty Step = 2nd-level = 3 Mana.

Suggested Full-Caster Mana Pool

```
Max Mana = floor(5L + L^2 / 12 - 1)
```

L is character level, found directly on the character sheet. Calculate the expression, then round down.

LEVEL	APPROX. MANA
1	4
5	26
10	57
15	92
20	132

Partial caster: roughly 65% of this value.
Primarily martial Catalyst user: roughly 40%.

Example - Level 10

5(10) + 10^2/12 - 1 = 50 + 8.33 - 1 = 57.33. Round down: **57 Mana**.

Playtest flag: Mana-pool totals are tuning knobs. They are intentionally easy to change without rewriting the rest of Arcane Compositry.

Applied Thaumaturgy: Magic Through Body & Gear

Traditional Compositors project magic outward. Applied Thaumaturges route it through weapons, armor, movement, stance, and the body itself.

Weapon Infusion

Do **not** add a full spell's damage to every Attack Chain strike. Instead, create an **Arcane Charge Pool**.

```
Charge Dice = Potency Damage Dice
```

For weapon infusions, those dice are usually **d6s**.

POTENCY III LIGHTNING INFUSION

Potency III = 6 dice, so the weapon gains **6d6 Charge**.

Each successful weapon hit may discharge **1d6**. A completed Attack Chain Finisher may discharge **2d6**.

Defensive Infusion

Armor magic should strengthen your active defense rather than simply granting blanket resistance.

```
Reinforcement = Number of Potency Damage Dice
```

Potency II has 4 damage dice, so a Potency II Geo Armor grants **+4 Reinforcement** to your Block system.

Why STR / DEX / CON?

Applied Thaumaturgy treats the body as part of the circuit:

- **STR:** force, impact, heavy weapon augmentation.
- **DEX:** speed, precision, delicate weapon routing.
- **CON:** armor, endurance, bodily reinforcement.

Identity rule: martials are not "bad wizards." They are specialists at *integrating* magic into physical action.

Arcane Attack Chains & What Happens on a Miss

08

Arcane Attack Chain

A caster can split one spell's damage pool across several linked attack rolls.

EXAMPLE

Potency III single-target Composition = **6d8**.

Three-projectile chain:

Attack 1: 2d8
Attack 2: 2d8
Attack 3: 2d8 Finisher

For a saving-throw Finisher, prefer **disadvantage on the save** rather than automatic failure.

Design Goal

Longer magical attacks feel like sustained pressure without multiplying a full spell's damage several times.

Missing Should Create a Choice

RECOVERY	WHAT IT DOES
Revector	Spend 1 Mana to reroll once.
Redirect	Send the projectile toward another legal nearby target, usually with a penalty.
Collapse	Detonate early for reduced effect.
Seed	Sacrifice direct damage so the Physical Component remains in the scene.
Ground	Safely terminate the magic.

Missed Geo projectile? It may create cover.
Missed Water? The floor becomes wet.
Missed Ice? A slick patch forms.

> A bad roll should create a complication, not erase a player's turn.

INTERRUPTION

Circuit Stability: When a Spell Is Hit Mid-Invocation

09

```
Stability Check = d20 + PB + IM
```

```
Stability DC = 10 + floor(P/2) + Additional Components + floor(Damage Taken/10)
```

What each input means

P: current spell Potency.

Additional Components: number of Components beyond the first. Geo = 0; Geo + Fire = 1; Geo + Fire + Volatility = 2.

Damage Taken: damage from the interrupting hit. Divide by 10 and round down.

PB / IM: same Proficiency Bonus and Invocation Modifier used for Arcane attacks.

Worked Example

Spell: Potency IV Geo + Fire.
Damage taken: 12.

10 base
+ floor(4/2) = 2
+ 1 additional Component
+ floor(12/10) = 1

DC = 14.

The caster rolls d20 + PB + IM against 14.

If the Stability Check Fails

GROUND

Safely cancel; recover part of the Mana if your table uses that option.

FORCE CLOSURE

Spend extra Mana and complete the spell under a drawback such as disadvantage.

BACKWASH

The spell completes, but the caster suffers Arcane backlash.

COLLAPSE

The spell releases early at reduced Potency or in an altered position.

Combat purpose: Counter-attacks against casters can now break or distort magic instead of merely removing hit points.

Tendril & Catalysts: The Body as Arcane Circuitry

> Catalyst = power source. Tendril = circuit. Body and mind = processor. Gesture = switch. Composition = output.

Tendril

Tendril is magic scripture bonded to the body in vine-like lines. It is not merely a tattoo: it is functional Arcane circuitry.

When dormant, Tendril may resemble ink, scar tissue, metallic filigree, or faintly colored veins. When invoked, Mana moves visibly through it and the lines glow in colors corresponding to the routed Components.

Functional Anatomy

- **Root Nodes:** where Catalyst energy enters the network.
- **Branches:** distribute Mana around the body.
- **Gates:** deliberately incomplete sections of circuit.
- **Terminals:** points joined by gestures.
- **Confluence Nodes:** places where Components combine.

Catalysts

Catalysts are magic-bearing metals, gems, crystals, or similar materials bound to the user. They act like Arcane batteries but are also status symbols, weapons technology, infrastructure, and cultural artifacts.

CAPACITY

How much total Mana the Catalyst can store.

THROUGHPUT

How much Mana it can safely discharge through Tendril in one invocation.

A Catalyst might hold 50 Mana but safely route only 5 at once. This prevents raw battery size from automatically granting mastery over extreme Potency.

> **Visual language:** knowledgeable people can often recognize the type of magic being prepared by watching where Tendrils light and what colors converge.

Prime -> Route -> Bridge -> Release

P Prime

The user draws Mana from the Catalyst. Root Tendrils light first.

R Route

Mana is sent through the Branches associated with the selected Component or Components.

B Bridge

A gesture joins open Terminals and closes the circuit. This is where Components synchronize.

R Release

The completed circuit produces the Composition: projectile, armor, field, strike, barrier, and so on.

Gestures Are Circuit Architecture

Touching two fingers may close one Gate. Pressing palms together may combine two Component branches. Gripping a weapon, drawing a blade, crossing forearms, or planting both feet can be a martial Bridge.

Read the Circuit

```
Arcana or Perception vs. DC 10 + Potency
```

A success can reveal a Component, Form, approximate Potency, or target. A strong success may reveal the entire Composition.

False Route / Arcane Feint

A skilled Compositor can deliberately light the wrong route before switching at the last moment. A simple version costs **1 Mana** and makes the Composition harder to read or defend against.

Martial flavor: the Fighter does not stop to "cast." Their fighting motion completes the circuit. The sword draw, stance, grip, or strike can be the Bridge.

REACTIVE MAGIC

Counter-Compositry: Magic Should Collide

11

Instead of every counter being "your spell disappears," Arcane Compositry lets defenders oppose the actual material, force, and route being used.

```
Counter Check = Invocation Check vs. Attacker's Arcane Save DC
```

If the proposed counter is especially logical or effective, a simple starting bonus is **+2**.

Examples

ATTACK	COUNTER	POSSIBLE RESULT
Fire	Water	Steam, suppression, obscured sight
Lightning	Geo	Grounded discharge into terrain
Wind	Sand	Blinding airborne grit
Lightning	Iron	Conducted current through metal
Fire	Ice / Water	Steam or thermal shock

Three Possible Outcomes

CANCEL

The defending Composition neutralizes the incoming effect.

REDIRECT

The defender changes the destination, path, or target.

TRANSFORM

The two spells create a third battlefield condition.

Avoid a rigid weakness chart. Judge physical and magical logic. The same counter can behave differently depending on terrain, Form, scale, and creativity.

Environmental Compositry

Wet floors conduct. Sand can become glass. Vegetation can burn or grow. Metal can channel electricity. Stone can ground or obstruct. The environment is not set dressing; it is a resource and a consequence engine.

PROGRESSION

Arcane Discovery & Codifying Player-Made Spells 12

Improvised Composition

A new idea begins as an improvised formula. The player chooses Components, Form, Potency, and modifiers using the normal construction rules.

Arcane Discovery

When a character finds a useful interaction - perhaps Sand + Fire becoming glass, or Water + Lightning creating a conductive trap - record it. Repeated use turns experimentation into technique.

Refinement

Downtime, research, mentors, diagrams, Catalyst testing, and repeated combat use can stabilize the exact Tendril route and timing.

Codification

Once reliable, the player may **Codify** the Composition. It becomes a named, repeatable spell with a precise circuit and established notation.

CHOOSE AN OPTIMIZATION

- Reduce Mana cost by 1.
- Increase range one category.
- Increase area slightly.
- Improve Circuit Stability.
- Reduce a specific effect penalty.
- Make Revector cheaper.
- Hide part of the Tendril route.

> The spell list can grow because of what the players actually invent during the campaign.

Example

A character repeatedly creates radiant fragments of heated Celestial material. After research and refinement, the technique becomes a formal spell: **Seraphine's Shattered Sun**. It did not exist before that character created it.

How Arcane Compositry Lives in the World

Existing D&D Spells Are Ancient Codifications

Fireball is not merely "Fire + Volatility + Burst." It is a heavily optimized circuit refined by generations of magical researchers. The same explanation applies to Shield, Misty Step, Magic Missile, and other established spells.

This is why Codified spells may keep familiar D&D statistics even when an improvised spell with similar ingredients would use the generic construction formulas.

Magic Has Lineage

A famous technique may carry the name of its inventor. Academies teach it. Armies adapt it. Rivals build counters. Scholars argue over attribution. A player's invention can become part of history.

Magical Identity

Compositors develop recognizable styles: Water + Ice duelists, Geo + Volatility siege casters, Iron + Lightning Applied Thaumaturges, or specialists in a single Physical Component.

Their preferred routes, gestures, Tendril colors, and spell shapes become signatures. A veteran may recognize an opponent before seeing their face simply by watching their Tendril pattern ignite.

Catalysts as Culture

Because Catalysts store and regulate Mana, they can be heirlooms, licenses, religious objects, military hardware, black-market goods, political symbols, or proof of social rank.

Long-Term Consequence

If a player invents a new Composition, the world can respond: apprentices ask to learn it, an academy offers to purchase the notation, enemies develop an anti-circuit, or a nation tries to weaponize the discovery.

Tendril is visible magic. Magic use leaves social information on the body. That can affect law, status, suspicion, fashion, religion, and identity far outside combat.

DM TOOLKIT

Enemy Compositors Without Giant Spell Lists

14

Give each spellcasting NPC an **Arcane Profile**: Known Physicals, Known Aspects, Known Forms, Maximum Potency, Mana, temperament, and one or two Signature Compositions.

Roll Arcane Intent

D6	INTENT
1	Direct damage / pressure
2	Battlefield control
3	Defense / protection
4	Positioning / movement
5	Disruption / break Guard or circuits
6	Signature or dramatic technique

Will They Improvise?

TEMPERAMENT	IMPROVISES ON...
Disciplined	d6 = 6
Adaptive	d6 = 5-6
Experimental	d6 = 3-6

Choose Potency

D6	POWER USED
1	About one-third maximum
2-3	About two-thirds maximum
4-5	Maximum minus 1
6	Maximum Potency

If the NPC is bloodied, desperate, enraged, or protecting something important, treat the Potency result as one category more aggressive.

WHY THIS WORKS

The NPC "invents" from the same Components the players use. The DM only needs a small profile, but combat still feels adaptive and personal.

Personality through rules: a conservative academy mage behaves differently from a reckless battlefield researcher before you write a single line of dialogue.

Attack Chains: The Core Loop

An Attack Chain is one sustained offensive sequence. A hit creates pressure, pressure creates another attack, and the defender decides when to spend resources to stop the exchange.

1. Start the Chain

Make a normal attack roll against the target's AC.

```
Attack Total = d20 + Attack Bonus
```

If the roll misses AC: use a Miss Recovery option on page 22. A miss does not automatically mean "your turn is over."

If the roll meets or beats AC: the target may take the hit or spend Guard on an active defense.

2. Resolve the Hit

If no defense stops it, deal damage. The attacker gains **1 Chain Momentum** and may make the next attack in the Chain, up to their maximum Chain Length.

3. Continue or Stop

The attacker may keep pressing, or voluntarily end the Chain after a successful hit to take a safer stance.

> **Design goal:** the attacker keeps making decisions, but the defender also keeps playing during the attacker's turn.

Suggested Maximum Chain Length

CHARACTER TIER	MAX CHAIN	FEEL
Levels 1-4	2	Short exchanges
Levels 5-10	3	Skilled combinations
Levels 11-16	4	Veteran pressure
Levels 17+	5	Master-level flurries

This is a baseline, not a class lock. Weapons, class features, monsters, and techniques can raise or lower Chain Length.

Momentum

Each successful strike in the current Chain grants **1 Chain Momentum**.

```
Chain Attack Bonus = +1 per Chain Momentum (max +3)
```

Chain Momentum exists only for the current Chain. It ends when the Chain is broken or voluntarily stopped.

Melee Pressure Rule

After a defender **takes damage from a melee hit** in the current Chain, they normally cannot Dodge later melee attacks in that same Chain. They may still Parry or Block.

Dodge becomes legal again if the defender creates meaningful distance, uses a feature that explicitly permits it, or the attacker loses pressure.

> Hit -> defender reacts -> damage -> Chain Momentum -> next attack -> interruption or Finisher.

ACTIVE DEFENSE

Guard, Dodge, Parry & Block

Active defense is optional. The normal attack roll still checks AC first; only an attack that would hit asks the defender whether the hit is worth spending Guard on.

Guard

```
Guard = 2 + Proficiency Bonus
```

PB is the creature's normal proficiency bonus. Guard refreshes at the **beginning of that creature's turn**.

SPEND	USE
1 Guard	Dodge, Parry, or Block
2 Guard	Counter-attack

Broken Guard

At **0 Guard**, a creature can still benefit from normal AC, but it cannot actively Dodge, Parry, Block, Counter-attack, or interrupt a Finisher until Guard returns.

Why this matters: several weaker allies can wear down a powerful defender's Guard so a heavy hitter can exploit the opening.

Dodge - Avoid the attack

```
Dodge = d20 + DEX modifier + PB if proficient in DEX saves
```

Spend 1 Guard. If the Dodge total **meets or exceeds the attack total**, the attack misses completely.

Perfect Dodge: beat the attack total by 5+. You may move 5 feet without provoking an opportunity attack. If that carries you outside the attacker's reach, the Chain ends.

Parry - Redirect the attack

```
Parry = d20 + STR or DEX modifier + PB if proficient with the parrying weapon
```

Spend 1 Guard. Meet or beat the attack total to stop the hit.

Perfect Parry: beat the attack total by 5+. The Attack Chain immediately ends. **Masterful Parry:** beat it by 10+. Once per round, you may make the resulting Counter-attack without paying its additional 2 Guard cost.

Block - Absorb the attack

Spend 1 Guard. The attack connects, but reduce its damage. Suggested baselines:

BLOCKING TOOL	DAMAGE REDUCTION
Weapon block	PB + STR modifier
Shield	1d8 + STR modifier
Heavy shield / equivalent	1d10 + STR modifier

Perfect Block: if damage is reduced to 0, the Chain ends.

A defense must make physical sense. You cannot normally parry a wall of flame with an ordinary dagger, but you might parry a conjured iron spear or block fire with an appropriate magical ward.

Breaking Chains & Counter-attacking

The defender's goal is not merely to reduce damage. Good defense can seize control of the exchange and turn defense into offense.

What Breaks a Chain?

EVENT	RESULT
Perfect Parry	Chain ends immediately.
Perfect Dodge exits reach	Chain ends.
Block reduces damage to 0	Chain ends.
Recover / Reposition / Feint	Chain ends safely.
Attacker is knocked away, restrained, disarmed, or otherwise unable to continue	Chain ends if the interruption meaningfully breaks the sequence.
Counter-attack lands	Original Chain ends; control may reverse.

Counter-attack

Once per round, a defender may spend **2 Guard** to Counter-attack when a clear opening occurs.

Common triggers:

- The attacker misses by 5 or more.
- The attacker rolls a natural 1.
- The defender scores a Perfect Parry.
- A Block reduces the attack's damage to 0.
- A special feature creates an opening.

Resolving a Counter

1. The opening occurs.
2. The defender spends 2 Guard.
3. The defender makes one immediate attack.
4. If it lands, the original Chain ends.
5. If the countering creature is allowed to Chain, that hit may become the first hit of its own Attack Chain.

Interrupting Without Damage

- Shove the attacker outside weapon reach.
- Grapple or bind the weapon arm.
- Disarm the weapon needed for the Chain.
- Raise terrain or cover between combatants.
- Teleport or force-move either combatant.
- Use a Composition that physically disrupts stance or footing.

Ally Interventions

For a highly reactive table, you may allow a creature to spend a Reaction plus Guard to protect an adjacent ally with a Block, Parry, shove, ward, or Counter-Compositry attempt.

> **Keep it readable:** limit most creatures to one Counter-attack each round. Otherwise two skilled duelists can recursively counter each other for too long.

> A strong defense does not simply say "no." It creates a chance for momentum to change hands.

Misses, Finishers & Voluntary Endings

A bad roll should create a problem to solve, not erase a player's turn. Attack Chains therefore give the attacker several ways to recover from a miss.

When an Attack Misses

RECOVERY	EFFECT
Recover	End the Chain safely and regain 1 Guard, up to your normal maximum.
Press the Attack	Continue the Chain. Your next attack is -2, and the defender gains +2 on an active defense against it.
Reposition	Move 5 feet without provoking from the current target; the Chain ends.
Feint	End the Chain and force the target to lose 1 Guard if it has any.
Wild Recovery	Spend 1 Guard and reroll the missed attack once. If the reroll also misses, you become Exposed: -2 to your next active defense before your next turn.

Voluntarily Ending a Chain

After a successful hit, the attacker can stop instead of pressing onward.

```
Defensive Posture = +2 to your first active defense before your next turn
```

This makes "always use the longest possible Chain" a choice rather than an automatic answer.

The Finisher

If an attacker reaches the **last attack of their maximum Chain** without the Chain being broken, that strike becomes a Finisher.

Finisher rule: make the attack roll normally, but the Finisher does not fail merely because it falls below AC. The roll still establishes the **Attack Total** for Dodge, Parry, Block, Counterplay, critical results, and other reactions.

If the defender cannot or chooses not to spend Guard on a legal defense, the Finisher hits. This represents the defender being worn down by the sustained sequence.

A Finisher can still be stopped by:

- a successful active defense;
- a legal Counter-attack trigger;
- an ally intervention;
- forced movement or other interruption;
- a class, monster, or magical feature.

Why Roll the Finisher?

The attack roll preserves interaction even though normal AC no longer cancels the strike. A high result makes the Finisher difficult to Parry or Dodge; a low result gives the defender a realistic chance to interrupt it.

> **Saving-throw magic:** never make a target automatically fail a save just because a magical Chain reached its Finisher. Use disadvantage on that save instead.

Escalation, Near Misses, Weapons & Class Identity

These modules add texture after the basic Chain system is comfortable. They are intentionally optional so the core rules stay fast.

Escalation: Offense Has a Cost

```
Defensive Penalty = -1 per 2 attacks attempted in the current Chain
```

After attempting four attacks, the attacker is at -2 on active defense until the Chain ends. Use this only if Momentum feels too safe or snowballs too easily.

Degrees of Miss

RESULT	OPTIONAL TREATMENT
Miss by 5+	Clean Miss; normal recovery options.
Miss by 1-4	Near Miss; choose a lesser outcome such as continue at -2, move the target 5 ft, force 1 Guard, or gain a small setup benefit.
Hit	Normal hit; Chain continues.
Beat AC by 5+	Strong Hit; optionally gain 1 extra Momentum, respecting the +3 cap.

Do not give every Near Miss every benefit. Choose one modest consequence.

Weapon Identity Examples

WEAPON	POSSIBLE CHAIN TRAIT
Dagger	+1 maximum Chain Length.
Rapier	+2 on attempts to achieve a Perfect Parry.
Greatsword	+2 damage for each previous hit in the current Chain.
Greataxe	Halve mundane Block reduction against its strikes.

More Weapon Hooks

WEAPON	POSSIBLE CHAIN TRAIT
Longsword	Reroll one failed Parry per enemy Chain.
Spear	A 5-ft Perfect Dodge does not automatically escape its reach.
Warhammer	Blocking its heaviest strikes may cost +1 Guard.
Shield	+1 maximum Guard and improved Block options.

Class Identity Hooks

FIGHTER - MASTER OF CHAINS

Reliable continuation, better Parry thresholds, weapon-specific techniques, or one miss per turn that does not immediately break rhythm.

BARBARIAN - SAVAGE MOMENTUM

Consecutive hits build damage rapidly, but long Chains create larger defensive penalties.

MONK - CHAIN SPECIALIST

Longer Chains with moderate individual damage; specific sequences can unlock trips, pushes, or stance changes.

ROGUE - OPENING HUNTER

Shorter Chains, but excellent Perfect Dodge/Parry payoffs, counters, and large rewards for exploiting openings.

SPELLCASTER - DISTRIBUTED BARRAGE

Split one Composition's damage pool across several attacks instead of repeating full spell damage.

Balance principle: longer Chains should not simply mean more free damage. Classes and weapons should trade Chain length, reliability, damage, Guard pressure, and defensive risk.

ARCANE INTEGRATION

Attack Chains + Arcane Compositry

Compositry should plug into the same exchange: magic can strengthen a Chain, defend against one, or become vulnerable to interruption while it is being invoked.

Weapon Infusions

Do not add a full spell's damage to every hit. Create an **Arcane Charge Pool**.

```
Charge Dice = Potency + 2 + floor(Potency / 3)
```

Weapon infusions normally use d6s. A Potency III infusion creates **6d6** of Charge.

- On a hit, spend 1 Charge Die for bonus damage.
- On a Chain Finisher, spend up to 2 Charge Dice.
- Unused dice last only as long as the paid duration allows.

Defensive Infusions

```
Reinforcement Value = number of Potency damage dice
```

Potency II has 4 damage dice, so a Geo armor infusion could add **+4** to a legal Block's damage reduction.

Arcane Attack Chains

For a multi-projectile Composition, divide the spell's normal damage pool across the Chain.

Example: Potency III focused magic = 6d8. A three-hit barrage could deal **2d8 / 2d8 / 2d8**.

Which Defense Is Legal?

ARCANE ATTACK	LIKELY DEFENSES
Stone projectile	Dodge, Parry, Block
Molten stone	Dodge, Parry, Block; heat may leak through
Pure fire wave	Dodge or magical / appropriate Block
Iron spear	Dodge, Parry, Block
Lightning	Dodge, specialized Block, grounding, Counter-Compositry

Interrupting a Caster

1. The caster Primes and begins Routing.
2. An enemy gains a Counter-attack or other legal interruption.
3. The interruption hits or physically disrupts the Bridge.
4. The caster makes a Circuit Stability Check.
5. Failure leads to Ground, Force Closure, Backwash, or Collapse.

```
Stability DC = 10 + floor(P/2) + Extra Components + floor(Damage/10)
```

A shove, grapple, disarm, severed stance, raised wall, or Counter-Composition can interrupt even without HP damage if it genuinely breaks the circuit.

Counter-Compositry: magical defense can also interrupt a Chain by changing the battlefield - freezing water underfoot, raising stone between duelists, grounding lightning, or transforming the incoming Composition.

WORKED COMBAT EXAMPLE

A Complete Attack Chain Exchange

Kael is a Fighter with Attack +7, maximum Chain 3, and 5 Guard. An elite knight has AC 17 and 5 Guard.

Attack 1

Kael rolls 14 + 7 = 21. The attack beats AC 17.

The knight spends 1 Guard to **Parry**, but rolls only 17. The Parry fails.

Kael deals 9 damage, gains **1 Chain Momentum**, and continues.

Attack 2

Kael now has +1 from Chain Momentum. He rolls **11 + 7 + 1 = 19**.

Because the knight already took melee damage in this Chain, ordinary Dodge is unavailable. The knight spends 1 Guard to **Block**.

Kael would deal 10 damage. The shield reduces 7, so the knight takes 3. Damage got through, so the Chain continues. Kael reaches **2 Momentum**.

Attack 3 - Finisher

This is Kael's final allowed attack. He still rolls to establish an Attack Total, but normal AC alone cannot make the Finisher miss.

The knight spends 1 Guard on a Parry and rolls high enough to beat Kael's total by 5+. **Perfect Parry.** The Chain ends.

Control Reverses

The Perfect Parry creates a Counter-attack opening. The knight has enough Guard remaining and spends **2 Guard** to Counter.

The Counter lands. Kael's offense is over, and the knight may now begin its own Chain if its rules allow.

Why This Is Interactive

- Kael chooses whether to keep pressing after every successful hit.
- The knight chooses whether each incoming hit is worth Guard.
- Dodge becomes less available once melee pressure is established.
- Block is reliable but may still allow the Chain to continue.
- Parry is riskier, but a Perfect Parry can reverse momentum.
- The Finisher is threatening without removing defensive agency.

Fast Table Procedure

1. Attack roll vs. AC.
2. If it would hit: defender may spend Guard.
3. Resolve Dodge, Parry, or Block.
4. If damage lands: gain Chain Momentum.
5. Continue, voluntarily stop, or reach Finisher.
6. If an opening appears: eligible defender may Counter.

> Do not narrate five isolated swings. Narrate one duel whose control is changing hand by hand.

COMBAT RESOURCE

Momentum Dice: Build the Combo, Then Cash It Out

> Momentum Die: d4 > d6 > d8 > d10 > d12

The Core Loop

1 BEGIN AT D4

The d4 is your baseline state. It cannot be spent; it represents a combo that has not built enough force yet.

2 LAND A HIT

Each successful attack that hits an enemy can step your Momentum Die up one size, to a maximum of d12.

3 BUILD OR SPEND

Once you are at d6 or higher, after a hit is confirmed you may either **build** one step higher or **spend** your current die on Damage or Stasis.

4 RESET

After you spend the die - whether the Stasis roll succeeds or fails - return to d4. A direct enemy hit that deals damage also resets you to d4.

What Does Not Reset It?

- Missing an attack: your die stays where it is.
- An enemy attack missing you.
- A successful Dodge or Parry.
- A Block that reduces the incoming damage to 0.
- Ending an Attack Chain normally.

DIRECT HIT RULE

Recommended: reset Momentum Dice when a hostile attack directly deals damage to you. Passive damage already ticking from poison, fire, terrain, or another lingering effect does not normally reset it unless the DM rules that the effect meaningfully breaks your rhythm.

DO NOT CONFUSE THE TWO MOMENTUMS

Chain Momentum is the temporary +1-per-hit Attack Chain bonus, capped at +3, and disappears when that Chain ends.

Momentum Die is your persistent combo resource. It can survive between turns and Attack Chains until it is spent or broken by an enemy hit.

Momentum Ladder

CURRENT DIE	ON A BUILD HIT	DAMAGE SPEND	STASIS OPTION
d4	Advance to d6	-	Baseline only; cannot be spent.
d6	Advance to d8	+1d6 damage	**Break** on 5-6
d8	Advance to d10	+1d8 damage	**Topple** on 7-8
d10	Advance to d12	+1d10 damage	**Daze** on 9-10
d12	Remain at d12	+1d12 damage	**Launch or Smash** on 11-12

Spend timing: confirm that the attack hit first. Then choose Damage or Stasis before resolving the Momentum effect. If you spend for Damage, roll the current die and add the result to that hit. If you spend for Stasis, roll the die against its Stasis threshold. Either way, the Momentum Die returns to d4 afterward.

Recommended anti-farming rule: one distinct successful attack roll can advance Momentum only one step, regardless of how many targets or damage packets it affects. Save-only area effects do not build Momentum by default.

Stasis: Trade Reliable Damage for a Powerful Opening

At d6 or higher, a successful hit can cash out the current Momentum Die as a Stasis attempt instead of rolling it for bonus damage. The stronger the die becomes, the stronger - and less likely - the Stasis result becomes.

DIE	SUCCESS	CHANCE	STASIS
d6	5-6	33.3%	Break
d8	7-8	25%	Topple
d10	9-10	20%	Daze
d12	11-12	16.7%	Launch or Smash

d6 - Break

Stasis roll: 5 or 6.

The hit briefly **Breaks the target's posture**, creating a sharp opening until the start of its next turn.

- Melee attacks against the target have **advantage**.
- Every successful melee or ranged hit against it deals an additional **1d6 bludgeoning or force damage**.
- The bonus applies once to each qualifying hit while Break lasts.

Use case: cash out early to create a team damage window rather than saving for a rarer high-tier Stasis.

d8 - Topple

Stasis roll: 7 or 8.

The target is forced down to a kneel or similarly compromised stance.

- Melee attacks against it have **advantage**.
- It **cannot Dodge or Parry**, but it may still **Block**.
- At the start of its next turn it regains its feet, but its **speed is halved for that turn**.

Use case: Topple is excellent for keeping a slippery defender inside melee pressure while still leaving Block as a defensive answer.

d10 - Daze

Stasis roll: 9 or 10.

The target stumbles and loses the stable posture needed for weapon defenses.

- Until the start of its next turn, it **cannot Parry or Block**.
- It may still **Dodge**, because it remains mobile enough to evade.
- At the beginning of its next turn, it makes a **Wisdom saving throw**. On a failure, it **cannot attack that turn** and its **speed is halved**.

```
Stasis Save DC = 8 + Proficiency Bonus + Momentum Ability Modifier
```

Momentum Ability Modifier: use the ability that powered the triggering attack - normally STR for heavy melee, DEX for finesse/ranged attacks, or the relevant Invocation Modifier for an Arcane attack. If a feature already provides its own save DC, use that instead.

Failed Stasis roll: the triggering attack still deals its normal damage, but the Stasis effect does not occur and no Momentum bonus damage is added. The Momentum Die is still spent and resets to d4.

d12 Stasis: Launch, Smash & Combat Integration

Reaching d12 means the attacker has maintained an extended combo without allowing an enemy to land a damaging hit. A d12 Stasis succeeds only on 11-12. On success, choose Launch or Smash if the triggering attack can physically or magically justify it.

Launch

On Stasis success:

- The triggering hit deals an additional **2d6 bludgeoning or force damage**.
- Launch the target **15 feet horizontally** in the direction of impact, or **15 feet upward** if the attack could reasonably lift it.
- If a horizontal Launch drives it into a hard obstacle or comparable hazardous collision - a sturdy wall, boulder, pit edge, and so on - it takes an additional **1d12 damage**. Other fall or hazard damage may also apply when appropriate.
- If launched upward, it becomes **Airborne**, opening a brief window for ranged attacks or thrown weapons, then takes **1d6 fall damage** when it lands.

Smash

On Stasis success:

- The target is violently driven into the ground as though gravity suddenly multiplied around it.
- It takes an additional **3d6 bludgeoning or force damage**.
- Its **speed becomes 0** until it recovers at the start of its next turn.
- **All attacks against it have advantage** until it recovers.

> **Fiction gate:** Smash must make sense. A downward hammer blow, overhead strike, gravity-infused attack, slam, or similar vector can Smash. A light stab or ordinary punch to the stomach cannot simply declare Smash without a feature that explains the force.

Airborne Timing

To make Launch usable at the table, do not resolve an upward Launch and its fall as the same instant. Keep the target Airborne until the end of the current Attack Chain or until immediate reactions are resolved. Creatures that have a legal reaction, readied attack, or other reactive feature may use eligible ranged or thrown attacks during that window. Then the target falls.

How Momentum Dice Interact With the Rest of Combat

SYSTEM	INTERACTION
Attack Chains	Every landed Chain attack can build the Momentum Die. Spending a Momentum Die does **not** automatically end the Attack Chain; only the die resets.
Guard / Defense	Dodge, Parry, or a Block that reduces damage to 0 protects your Momentum Die. If a Block still lets direct enemy damage through, your Momentum Die resets to d4.
Counter-attacks	A landed Counter-attack can both reset the original attacker's Momentum Die and build the countering creature's own die one step.
Finishers	After a Finisher lands, the attacker may spend an available Momentum Die normally. Stasis still requires its die threshold; the Finisher does not guarantee Stasis.
Applied Thaumaturgy	Arcane Charge Dice and Momentum Dice are separate resources and may affect the same hit if both are legally spent.
Ranged / Arcane Attacks	Successful attack rolls can build Momentum unless a feature says otherwise. Save-only area effects normally do not build it.

Example: Building Into Topple

Kael starts at **d4**. His first hit advances him to **d6**. His second hit could spend d6, but he chooses to build and advances to **d8**. On his next successful hit he chooses **Stasis: Topple** instead of advancing. He rolls the d8 and gets an **8**: Topple

TABLE REFERENCE

One-Page Attack Chain Cheat Sheet

Core Loop

1. Roll **d20 + Attack Bonus** vs. AC.
2. If it would hit, defender may take it or spend Guard.
3. Resolve Dodge, Parry, or Block.
4. If damage lands, attacker gains 1 Chain Momentum.
5. Continue until stopped, voluntarily ending, or reaching Finisher.
6. When an opening appears, an eligible defender may Counter-attack.

```
Guard = 2 + Proficiency Bonus
```

```
Chain Momentum = +1 to later Chain attacks per hit (max +3)
```

Maximum Chain Baseline

LEVEL	MAX CHAIN
1-4	2
5-10	3
11-16	4
17+	5

Active Defenses - 1 Guard

DEFENSE	RESOLUTION
Dodge	d20 + DEX + PB if DEX-save proficient. Meet attack total. Beat by 5+ = move 5 ft safely.
Parry	d20 + STR/DEX + PB if weapon proficient. Beat by 5+ = Chain ends.
Block	Reduce damage. Reduce to 0 = Chain ends.

Counter-attack - 2 Guard

Once per round when an opening appears: miss by 5+, natural 1, Perfect Parry, Perfect Block, or a special feature. Make one immediate attack; if it lands, the original Chain ends and your own Chain may begin.

Miss Recovery

CHOICE	EFFECT
Recover	End Chain; regain 1 Guard.
Press	Continue; next attack -2, defense against it +2.
Reposition	Move 5 ft safely; Chain ends.
Feint	Chain ends; target loses 1 Guard.
Wild Recovery	Spend 1 Guard; reroll. Miss again = Exposed (-2 next defense).

Finisher

The final attack of an uninterrupted maximum Chain **cannot miss from AC alone**. Roll anyway to establish the Attack Total. A legal active defense, counter, forced movement, ally intervention, or special feature can still stop it.

Melee Pressure

After taking melee damage in a Chain, the defender normally cannot Dodge later melee hits in that Chain unless distance or a feature restores the option.

> **Voluntary stop:** after a successful hit, end the Chain for Defensive Posture: +2 to your first active defense before your next turn.

Remember: Guard is a choice. Do not roll a defense against every hit automatically.

> **Momentum Dice are separate:** your persistent combo die runs d4 > d6 > d8 > d10 > d12. It survives between Chains until spent or a direct enemy hit deals damage. See pages 26-28.

TABLE REFERENCE

One-Page Arcane Compositry Cheat Sheet

Build a Composition

1. Component(s) **2.** Form **3.** Potency **4.** Modifiers **5.** Resolve

```
Mana = Core + Composite + Range + Area + Duration + Effect
```

POTENCY	CORE MANA	DAMAGE DICE
I	2	3
II	3	4
III	5	6
IV	6	7
V	7	8
VI	9	10
VII	10	11
VIII	11	12
IX	13	14

Damage die: d8 focused, d10 risky/heavy, d6 area, d4 persistent.

```
Attack = d20 + PB + IM
```

```
Save DC = 8 + PB + IM
```

Common Costs

MODIFIER	COST
2 Components	+1
3 Components	+3
60 / 120 / 300 ft	+1 / +2 / +3
10 / 20 / 40 / 60 ft area	+1 / +2 / +3 / +4
1 min / 10 min / 1 hr	+1 / +2 / +3
Minor / Strong / Major effect	+1 / +2 / +3

Interruption

```
Stability DC = 10 + floor(P/2) + Extra Components + floor(Damage/10)
```

Fail: Ground, Force Closure, Backwash, or Collapse.

Miss Recovery

Revector · Redirect · Collapse · Seed · Ground

Tendril Invocation

Prime -> Route -> Bridge -> Release

System Philosophy

Use logic, let the environment matter, reward creative Composites, and turn failure into a new decision rather than a dead turn.

When unsure: choose the closest existing cost, resolve the moment quickly, and tune the exact rule after the session.